For almost everyone else involved, the stupidity lay in elevating plausible deniability over the needs of Brigade 2506. As the CIA Inspector-General concluded, plausible deniability was ‘a pathetic illusion’. Yet that illusion drove the President’s decisions. For many of his critics, the stupidity was less important than the hypocrisy.

Ghost at the feast?

There is, perhaps, one element in mitigation of Kennedy’s errors of judgement, which suggests one of his calculations was far from stupid. Indeed, it was crucial. Once the operation was falling apart, officials pressed him to sanction overt US intervention. Admiral Burke pleaded to allow the US navy to save the landing at Playa Giron. But the President remained steadfast in holding to what he said in public and to his advisers in private. This may well have been primarily attributable to avoiding ‘a fucking slaughter’ along the lines of the Soviet invasion of Hungary in 1956. Soviet intervention was designed to stop a revolution (or counter-revolution depending which side of the barricades you were on). US intervention in Cuba would have been designed to promote a revolution (or counter-revolution, depending which side of the barricades you were on). Almost certainly, US troops would have been embroiled in what, during consideration of an invasion in October 1962, Maxwell Taylor termed ‘that deep mud in Cuba’.[88] Overt US intervention in Cuba in April 1961 would unquestionably have led to many US and Cuban casualties.

Yet John F. Kennedy was not simply concerned with his image in the history books. In 1961 he confronted a range of Cold War challenges across the globe. His biggest problem lay in Europe. West Berlin presented considerable diplomatic challenges, not only in dealing with Moscow, but in handling Washington’s European allies in Bonn, Paris, and London. Beyond that, however, lay a far greater problem. If Khrushchev threatened the removal of US, British and French forces from West Berlin, as he had first done in 1958 (and would soon threaten again in 1961), the city could not be defended by conventional means. If Khrushchev sent his tanks into West Berlin, Kennedy’s choice would be to use nuclear weapons or accept